



This miniature from the *Annalistic Code* of the 16th century depicts the “Battle of the Ice,” fought on the frozen waters of Lake Peipus, Novgorod.

IN 1241, THE GERMAN TRADING TOWNS OF LUBECK AND HAMBURG

formed an alliance to protect the **Baltic trade routes**. This was the first act in the formation of the **Hanseatic League** (from the medieval Latin *hansa*, meaning a group or association). Lübeck quickly became the center of expanding German trade in the Baltic region, which extended along the Russian rivers as far as **Novgorod**, and linked to the European trading centers of **England and Flanders**.

In 1242, the efforts of the **Teutonic Knights** (see 1236–40)



RECONQUISTA

The notion of the *Reconquista*—the Christian reconquest of Islamic Spain—as a single, continuous project, is a myth, first created by clerical propagandists in the 14th century. In practice, the advance of the Christian kingdoms was by degrees, driven by the need for land, and facilitated by Muslim dissension and advances in military technology.

Medieval trade

A manuscript illumination of the port of Hamburg, a founder member of the **Hanseatic League**, which had its roots in an alliance of 1241 with Lübeck.



to extend their Livonian territories eastward and launch the conversion of the Russians from the Greek to the Roman church were checked by defeat at the **Battle of Lake Peipus**. Led by **Alexander Nevski**, prince of Novgorod, the Russians

checked the knights' progress and Lake Peipus thereafter served as the eastern limit of Livonia.

In a series of stunning victories in Eastern and Central Europe, the **Mongol armies** destroyed all opposition. Early in 1241, an army of horsemen crossed the frozen Vistula River into Poland, sacking Krakow and defeating an alliance of **Poles, Silesians, and Teutonic Knights** at Leignitz in April.

Just three days later, another force under **Batu** (see 1236–40) overwhelmed the Hungarian army in their camp at Mohi. By December, Batu was destroying Pest, the largest city in Hungary. The Mongols had reached the gates of Vienna when, in 1242, the news reached them that Ogodei, the Great Khan, had died. As was

traditional, Batu withdrew his forces back to Karakorum, the Mongol capital, for the **election of a new leader**. Elsewhere, Mongol forces had penetrated the Indian subcontinent, sacking Lahore in 1241.

In 1244, **Jerusalem**, which had been under partial Christian control since Frederick II's treaty with the sultan of Egypt (see 1226–30), was **lost to medieval Christians** for the final time. The Egyptian sultan, Ayyub, was engaged in a contest with the Syrian branch of the **Ayyubids** (see 1171–75) at Damascus, which had allied itself with the Christian Crusader kingdoms. In 1244, Ayyub's forces overran Jerusalem and **expelled the Christians**.



In this 16th-century painting, Ferdinand III, King of Castile and Leon, accepts the surrender of the city of Seville from the Moors in 1248.

IN 1247, FERDINAND III OF CASTILE AND LEON

(c. 1199–1252) laid siege to the Moorish city of Seville. It fell to him in 1248, and with it the **last Moorish kingdom in Spain**—with the exception of Granada. Here, Mohammad ibn-Yusuf ibn Nasr had established the **Nasrid dynasty** in 1230. By 1238, the Nasrids had begun to reconstruct an old fortress, the **Alhambra**, which would become one of the wonders of world architecture by the mid-14th century (see 1350–55). In 1246, the emir of Granada agreed to become Ferdinand's vassal, but the last relic of Moorish al-Andalus would resist Christian pressure until 1492 (see 1490–92).

Louis IX of France (1214–70) was much respected throughout Europe and had a reputation for justice. Under his reign, royal control was extended to the Mediterranean, and the previously autonomous realms of Languedoc and Provence would become part of **French Capetian** territories. In 1244, Louis “took the cross,” embarking on a crusade in 1248.

Theobald of Navarre had launched a crusade in 1239, but it was so unsuccessful that it is not usually recognized as an ordinate crusade; Louis' crusade of 1248 is accounted the **Seventh**, the last Crusade of this magnitude ever undertaken. Louis landed in Egypt and took Damietta without opposition, but in 1250 his army was **destroyed by the Egyptians** at Fariskur and he was taken captive. His mother, Blanche of Castile, raised a large ransom to buy his freedom.

The **Mamluks** (or Mamelukes) of Egypt were slave soldiers captured from Turkic and Circassian tribes (of the Pontic-Caspian steppes), who formed the main component of the Ayyubid army. Eventually they became strong enough to take power for themselves **murdering Turan Shah**, the last Ayyubid sultan of Egypt, in 1250. At first the Mamluk commander Izz-ad-Din Aybak used the sultan's widow as a puppet ruler, but he soon married her and founded the **Mamluk dynasty**, the first slave dynasty to hold power in its own name.

THE CRUSADES

- 1096–99 **FIRST CRUSADE**
- 1145–49 **SECOND CRUSADE**
- 1189–92 **THIRD CRUSADE**
- 1202–04 **FOURTH CRUSADE**
- 1213–21 **FIFTH CRUSADE**
- 1228–29 **SIXTH CRUSADE**
- 1248–54 **SEVENTH CRUSADE**

1241 Mongols ravage Europe and sack Lahore in northern India

1241 Formation of Hanseatic League

1242 Battle of Lake Peipus: Alexander Nevski defeats Teutonic Knights

1243 Battle of Köse Dag: Mongols defeat Seljuk Rum of Anatolia

1244 Fall of Montségur, last great stronghold of the Cathars

1246 Provence becomes part of Capetian France

1248 Cologne cathedral burns down; reconstructed in gothic style

1248 Ferdinand III completes conquest of al-Andalus, apart from siege of Seville

1249 Franciscan friar Roger Bacon records recipe for gunpowder

1248 Seventh Crusade: Louis IX of France lands in Egypt

1250 Mamluk dynasty founded in Egypt